with no false roofing or plastering on the walls. Electricity was a flickering bulb, that too if the village feeder line was through. We all had our personal petromax lamp, which was looked after most lovingly. It was a source of both light and warmth in the winters, but a nuisance in the summers, attracting all manner of insects and making us sweat copiously. The TRS huts were supposed to have a life of five years but looked as if they had been around forever. There was no attached bathroom either and it was all dry sanitation, a hole in the ground in the 'bathroom' tent. To get the wives there was madness, but we did so anyways, to spend as much time together, because you never knew what fate had in store. Veena was still completing her final year at JNU, New Delhi, so she could join me only during the holidays. As Veena once put it, 'You really have to be in love', to put up with such primitive conditions.

It was during this tenure that two landmark interrelated events occurred. The first was the storming of the Golden Temple in June 1984, followed by the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards in October of the same year. Being in a Sikh unit, both events had to be handled delicately. Discipline had to be maintained but the sentiments of the men and the hurt they felt had also to be respected. Those six months were difficult times, but we negotiated it because of the strong familial bonds that the paltan had. Some basic precautions were taken. For example, the keys to the *kote* (armoury) and ammunition magazine were kept in the custody of an officer at all times and the duty officer would sleep on the kote premises at night. There was no Internet or social media back then, which was perhaps a good thing, but rumours abounded. The CO and Company Commanders regularly spoke to all the men, giving them the facts. The Gurudwara parade was done more seriously, with

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